returning to their home base after every ‘project’. While the exact breakdown of the demographic split between long-term and short-term migrants is not known, it is estimated that smaller and poorer states send out anywhere between 30–40 per cent folks as short-term migrants from all the people who leave. Long-term migrants are more likely to be educated, come from upper income groups, are forward caste and have procured ration cards in the cities of work. In contrast, short-term migrants are less educated and tend to come from poorer sections of the society. A World Bank working paper in 2018, authored by Gaurav Nayyar and Kyoung Yang Kim, demonstrated that short-term migrants are far more likely to migrate interstate and are at the mercy of their ‘contractors’, whereas long-term migrants tend to stay within the state and engage in more ‘permanent’ jobs such as domestic help. The study also showed that a third of short-term migrants are most likely engaged in the construction sector and usually the logistics of moving them to the ‘city of duty’ is arranged by the contractor.[1] Due to the temporariness of the arrangement, it is not possible for short-term migrants to build social capital, which often comes in handy in times of distress as you can rely on communities and their systems to fulfil your needs. For instance, if one was to become infected with the virus, in the presence of abundant social capital one would be able to rehabilitate the rest of their family or room-mates in homes of neighbours or relatives living nearby. The person infected would also be able to access the social ecosystem where someone would supply them food for exchange of a pending favour. They would also likely have better access to government schemes due to a network of folks who are party or government workers in the community. In short, social capital builds the identity of an individual in the community and that identity can then be capitalized to make the best use of the social ecosystem, i.e., social capital. Equipped with the aforementioned information, it would be safe to assume that during a time of crisis like the announcement of a national lockdown and due to the absence of social capital, a large proportion of short-term migrants would have felt extremely financially insecure. They would have been laid off, displaced or left in the lurch by their contractors, not even knowing how to return to their home towns.

Almost immediately after the announcement of the nationwide lockdown, flocks of migrants began to crowd at interstate bus stations and major railway stations in an effort to find a means of public transport to on